The Main Complex

Of course, when people think about the Taj Mahal, the image immediately brought to mind is the main complex itself, a central area that contains three buildings: the Mausoleum, the Mosque (which is to the left when looking at the complex from the gardens) and the Guesthouse. The Mosque and Guesthouse are, from their exterior, identical structures that maintain the harmonious symmetry of the complex, though the Mosque's interior is different because it faces Mecca.



The interior of the mosque. Picture by Bjørn Christian Tørrissen

After taking photos, the visitor may approach the Mausoleum, but photos are no longer permitted inside the structure itself. The building sits on its own marble plinth, and upon entering through the front gate of the iwan, visitors pass into a small entry room, and from there into a short hallway that enters into the central room of the complex, directly underneath the soaring dome. Within this room is a central area separated from the visitor by a marble screen, and within this screen are the cenotaphs of Mumtaz Mahal and Shah Jahan. The cenotaph of Mumtaz is in the very center of the chamber, while